heading on through a blizzard to apprehend Dost Mohammad with only thirteen British officers. That night, Outram slept in thick snow, aware he might well die the following morning, but determined to do what he could to arrest or else kill the Amir. Afterwards he remembered that he had never been ‘more happy than on this night, under the exciting expectation of so glorious a struggle in the morning’. But the struggle never took place. Outram and his men galloped down the pass into the wide Bamiyan valley to find that Dost Mohammad had just that morning fled north of the Hindu Kush, escaping out of their reach beyond Saighan to Tash Qurgan, and into the territory of the independent Uzbek leader, the Mir Wali, ‘who is at enmity with Shah Shuja’. Outram now had no option but to write back to Macnaghten that ‘there being, under such circumstances not the slightest hope of our now overtaking the fugitive within the Shah’s territories, to which we have been restricted, and the officers of our cavalry having represented that their horses are incapable, through want of food or rest, of making further forced marches immediately, we have here been compelled to relinquish the pursuit’.[30]

That night, Dost Mohammad and his followers made it safely to the shelter of Khamard, the fortress of the slave-trading Mir Wali. ‘The Amir spent the next two months as honoured guest of the Uzbeks,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata,

> and from there he went on to Balkh where the governor received him in a guest-house in a beautiful garden. While he was in Balkh, letters arrived from Nasrullah Khan, the ruler of Bukhara, by camelpost, requesting the Amir to grace his court with his presence. The Amir left his family and dependents in Balkh and rode together with his heir Akbar Khan to Bukhara, the city of the Islamic sciences, where he was received with royal hospitality and he was given a private palace as his residence and a small allowance to meet his daily expenses.[31]

It is not entirely clear what went wrong in Bukhara, but after a few weeks Dost Mohammad fell out with his hosts: Mirza ‘Ata suggests that this was due to some disrespectful remarks made by Akbar Khan, the Amir’s hot-tempered son. It may also have been because Nasrullah resented Dost Mohammad’s earlier attempts to seize the disputed border city of Balkh, claimed by both amirs, and now objected to his plan to have the ‘ulema of Bukhara declare a jihad on his behalf. Either way, harsh words were then exchanged between the two, and the Barakzais left the city having deeply offended Nasrullah Khan. The cunning and ruthless (and possibly even